Q+A

WIZARD OF WORDS

Padma Shri-awardee **Prasoon Joshi** on his foray into theatre with his first musical *Rajadhiraaj: Love, Life, Leela*, and more

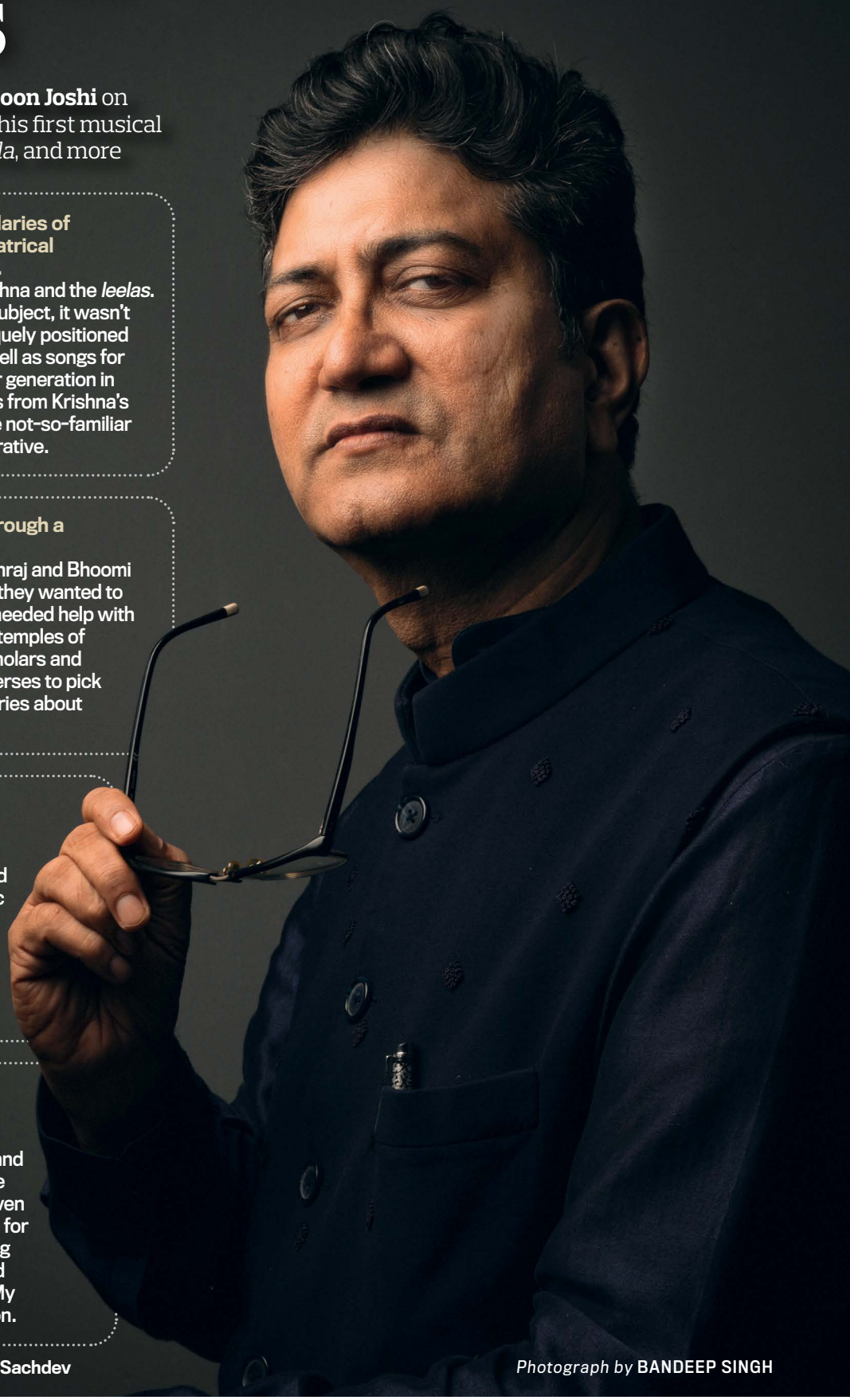
Q. You have pushed the boundaries of storytelling with the mega theatrical *Rajadhiraaj: Love, Life, Leela*...
A lot has been written about Krishna and the *leelas*. Given the sheer expanse of the subject, it wasn't easy to do justice to it. I was uniquely positioned to write the script, dialogue as well as songs for *Rajadhiraaj*. Keeping the younger generation in mind, I picked out a few episodes from Krishna's vast life—some familiar and some not-so-familiar ones—weaving them into the narrative.

Q. How did you approach it through a new lens?
The project had the force of Dhanraj and Bhoomi Nathwani. As Krishna devotees, they wanted to create something impactful but needed help with form and execution. I visited the temples of Nathdwara in Rajasthan, met scholars and researchers, and read ancient verses to pick up interesting, lesser-known stories about Krishna's life.

Q. How pivotal is the role of music in theatre?
Music has always played an important role in both cinema and theatre. Collaborating with music directors Sachin and Jigar in this production was a joy. *Rajadhiraaj* had another unique aspect—most songs were sung live by the performers.

Q. Any other projects in the pipeline?
While I delved into and wrote at length about the Bhagavad Gita and the Krishna-Sudama episode, we could not include it in the play, given its length. I have enough material for two more plays! I am also working on songs for another musical and exploring subjects for children. My poetry book is nearing completion.

- with Geetika Sachdev



Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**